Signé PAR Em

No 06

COLLECTION
BUYERS

Visiting a Property

The essential checks to help you make the right choice.



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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It presents general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. Every real estate situation is different, and you should consult the appropriate professionals before making a decision about a transaction.

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COLLECTION BUYERS · GUIDE NO. 06

Property Visit & Inspection Checklist

The buyer’s checklist for seeing past the decor

A beautiful kitchen and careful home staging can make you forget the essentials: the structure, water, electricity, roof. This guide gives you an inspector's eye for your visits, room by room and system by system.

It does not replace the professional inspection - essential - but it helps you spot the signs on the first visit, ask the right questions and decide which ones are worth an offer.

After each chapter, a lined “My Notes” page serves as a visit notebook: write down what you see, property by property.

A successful visit is a methodical visit: you look in the right order, you note the right clues, and you distinguish what is easily repaired from what is expensive. This guide gives you a room-by-room grid, from the exterior to the systems.

Objective: identify the real issues behind the staging, and transform your observations into precise questions for the inspection.

CHAPTER

Before entering: the exterior and the terrain

> *Read the property from the sidewalk and the lot.*

- Land: does the slope move water away from the foundation, or towards it?
- Visible foundation: significant cracks, crumbling, traces of humidity?
- Roof: apparent age, warped or missing shingles, moss, sagging?
- Gutters and drainage: present, clear, directed away from the house?
- Exterior cladding, windows and doors: condition, sealant, signs of rot?
- Trees too close, parking, immediate neighborhood and noise.

The exterior tells of general maintenance: a neglected envelope often announces surprises inside.

Before even ringing the bell, take thirty seconds on the sidewalk: the location, the slope of the land and the general condition already tell a lot. A property that is well maintained on the outside is often also well maintained on the inside; the opposite is a signal not to be ignored.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Walk completely around the house before entering. The facade is highlighted; it's often the back and sides that tell the truth about maintenance.*

CHAPTER

The basement: where everything is visible

> *Detect water, cracks and system conditions.*

- Humid or musty odors, water stains on the walls and floor.
- Cracks in the slab or foundation walls (fine vs. large).
- Traces of infiltration, water level marks, sump pump present?
- Insulation, vermiculite (possible asbestos) in old attics/walls.
- Furnace, water heater, electrical entrance: visible age and condition.

In Quebec, a dry and healthy subsoil is a major asset; Water is the number one enemy of buildings and the source of the most expensive repairs.

The basement is the most honest place in a house: it's where water, cracks and DIY repairs are seen. Be wary of a freshly painted basement just before sale - it may hide traces of infiltration. A dehumidifier that runs constantly is also a clue.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Open your nostrils as much as your eyes in the basement. A smell of humidity that we try to mask (strong air freshener, dehumidifier running) always deserves a direct question.*

CHAPTER

Systems: electricity, plumbing, heating

> *Check the functional heart of the house.*

Electricity

- Panel: capacity (100 A minimum often desirable), known risky brand, wires correctly identified?
- Presence of old problematic wiring; earthed sockets.

Plumbing and heating

- Water pressure and flow, marks under sinks, age of water heater.
- Type of heating (electric baseboard heaters, furnace, heat pump) and costs.
- Buried or above ground oil tank: a point of vigilance and insurability.

For systems, note the age of the large components (roof, heating, water heater, windows): they are the ones that are expensive to replace. A dated electrical panel, old plumbing or a heating system at the end of its life must enter into your budget calculation after purchase.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Request Hydro-Quebec bills for the last 12 months. They reveal the true cost of heating - often more telling than a description on the sheet.*

CHAPTER

The interior, room by room

> *Locate the clues behind the decoration.*

- Floors: levels, squeaks, stains, “leaning” floors.
- Windows: condensation between the panes (sealant breakage), easy opening.
- Ceilings and corners: yellow halos (past infiltration), cracks.
- Kitchen and bathrooms: ventilation, sealant, signs of water damage.
- Doors that close poorly or stepped cracks: signs of structural movement.

A recent renovation is nice, but always ask: was it done with permits and by professionals? A cosmetic renovation can hide a problem rather than fix it.

Inside, look beyond the decoration: level floors, doors that close well, absence of halos on the ceiling, windows without condensation between the panes. The decor is easy to change; the structure and the envelope, no. Don't fall in love with a kitchen so much that you forget about a loose foundation.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Be wary of a freshly painted isolated wall, especially in the basement or under a window: sometimes we refresh... sometimes we camouflage a recent water stain.*

CHAPTER

From visit to professional inspection

> *Transform your observations into a decision and an offer condition.*

Your visit is used to filter and target. As soon as you are seriously interested in a property, make a promise to purchase conditional on an inspection by a recognized professional, and accompany them on site.

Give him your notes: the points you have identified will direct his attention. Their report will confirm the extent of the problems and give you leverage to renegotiate, demand fixes, or walk away if necessary.

Your visit does not replace the inspection: it serves to filter and target. As soon as you are seriously interested in a property, make a promise to purchase conditional on an inspection by a recognized professional, and accompany them to ask your questions and understand the report.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Keep this visit book for each property. Compared cold, it prevents you from confusing the crush of the moment with the best decision.*

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

> *Your next steps, concretely.*

This week

1. Print this checklist and use it at each visit.
2. Request energy bills and renovation history.

Within 30 days

1. Retain a recognized inspector and provide for the inspection condition.
2. Compare my cold visit books before offering.

Then

1. Have the selected property inspected by accompanying the inspector.

My visit kit

1. Bring a flashlight, a level (or a ball) and something to take notes and photos.
2. Note the age of the major components and request invoices for recent work.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Pre-purchase inspection: professional examination, to be conditional on the offer.
- Sealant breakage: foggy window between the panes, to be replaced.
- Sump pump: drains water from the basement, a sign of a damp area.
- Oil tank: buried or above ground, point of insurability.
- Stepped crack: possible indication of foundation movement.
- Building envelope: roof, walls, windows and insulation - the barrier against water and cold.
- Sealant breakage: condensation between the panes of a thermos window.
- French drain: peripheral drain evacuating water around the foundation.
- Inspection condition: clause making the purchase dependent on a satisfactory report.
- Apparent defect: defect visible during normal examination, not covered by the legal guarantee.

GO FURTHER

Quiz - test yourself

1. The first instinct outside is to check:

A) The color of the door

B) That the ground keeps water away from the foundation

C) The name of the street

D) The curtains

2. In the basement, enemy number one is:

A) Painting

B) Water and humidity

C) Light

D) The carpet

3. Vermiculite in an old building may contain:

A) Gold

B) Asbestos

C) Drinking water

D) Nothing

4. A foggy window between the panes indicates:

A) A good sealant

B) A sealant breakage

C) Rain

D) Good insulation

5. To find out the true cost of heating, ask:

A) The neighbor's opinion

B) Hydro-Quebec bills from the last 12 months

C) The descriptive sheet

D) The weather

6. “Staircase” cracks and stuck doors can signal:

A) A beautiful decoration

B) A structural movement

C) Good ventilation

D) Nothing

7. A recent renovation should always raise the question:

A) What color?

B) Was it done with permit and by professionals?

C) How many photos?

D) When is supper?

8. This checklist:

A) Replaces professional inspection

B) Completes the visit but does not replace the inspection

C) Is useless

D) Used by the notary

Answers

1. B - Drainage protects the foundation (chap. 1).

2. B - Water causes the most expensive repairs (chap. 2).

3. B - This is a point of health vigilance (chap. 2).

4. B - The thermos sealer is broken (chap. 4).

5. B - The invoices give the real cost (chap. 3).

6. B - Possible indications of foundation movement (chap. 4).

7. B - Cosmetics can hide a problem (chap. 4).

8. B - The professional inspection remains essential (chap. 5).

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You now have the right keys in hand.

Every real estate journey is different.

If you would like to go further,
I would be happy to discuss
your project with you.



Make informed decisions.
Choose with confidence.
Live without regrets.
See you soon,
Emilie ☺

Emilie Cauvier

RESIDENTIAL & COMMERCIAL
REAL ESTATE BROKER

(514) 774-9818

emilie@equipecauvier.com

guidesimmoquebec.com